

Sweetgum

Liquidambar styraciflua



Origin

Native to the southeastern and south-central United States, as well as parts of Mexico and Central America.

Look for

Its star-shaped leaves with five to seven pointed lobes are unmistakable, and the spiky, golf-ball-sized seed pods that litter the ground beneath it in winter are just as distinctive.

IDENTIFICATION TIPS

- Leaf: star-shaped, five to seven pointed lobes -- unmistakable among street trees.
- Fruit: spiky, round seed balls, about golf-ball sized, littering the ground in winter.
- Fall color: yellow, orange, red, and purple, often all on one tree.
- Commonly confused with: maple (sweetgum's star shape has more, narrower points and its fruit is a spiky ball, not a winged samara).

THROUGH THE SEASONS

Spring	Star-shaped leaves emerge glossy green.
Summer	Deep green, star-shaped leaves and small round flower clusters.
Fall	Spectacular multicolor display -- yellow, orange, red, and purple often on the same tree at once.
Winter	Spiky, round seed balls persist on bare branches for months.

DID YOU KNOW

- Its fall color display is considered one of the most dramatic of any North American tree, because several different pigments break down at different rates in the same leaf.
- The name 'sweetgum' comes from the fragrant resin the tree produces, historically chewed like gum and used in traditional medicine.